

Gokulam Kerala regains Kerala Premier League crown



The monsoon is around the corner. But its precursor is already in Kerala, and it announced its presence in a rather emphatic manner in Thrissur on May 31.

Strong rain marked the final of the Kerala Premier League (KPL) football at the EMS Corporation Stadium. In the clash between the two Kozhikode-based clubs, Gokulam Kerala and Calicut FC, it rained goals, too, with Gokulam winning 3-2 to regain the title it last won five years ago.

Gokulam was indeed the deserving winner against Calicut which had to catch up right through the match. The Calicut men were stunned by Mohamed Bilal's devastating twin strike within the first five minutes of the final. A goal from Ameen — his third in two matches — had given them hope eight minutes before the interval, but they suffered another setback when Muhammed Sinan made it 3-1 for Gokulam. Substitute Rifhath Ramzan's goal — header off a corner kick — in the injury time came too late in the day for Calicut. It only made the final scores more respectable.

Earlier, Gokulam's first goal came off a superb pass down the left flank by Sinan, who beat the defence to set up Bilal. Just three minutes later, a long ball from well inside his own half by Aman Gaikwad found Bilal in the thick of the action once again.

The Gokulam men may have struggled in the I-League this season, but they were not going to squander a two-goal lead inside five minutes on this night.

P. K. AJITH KUMAR



Triumphant: Members of the Gokulam Kerala team celebrate after defeating Calicut FC in the final. SPECIALARRANGEMENT

SPORTOON

